

UAEPROPERTYWILLS

Talking to Your Parents About UAE Property

A practical guide for adult children of foreign property owners in the UAE. How to raise the topic, handle objections, and take the next step.

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1. Why this matters

Your parents own property in the UAE. Perhaps an apartment in Dubai, a villa in Abu Dhabi, or an investment property in one of the other emirates. It was a significant purchase, and they may be rightfully proud of it.

But there is a question that few families consider until it is too late: what happens to that property if one of your parents passes away?

If there is no locally registered will, the UAE applies its own succession laws to property within its borders. A will made in your parents' home country is generally not recognized for real estate on UAE soil. The result: frozen assets, a court-led probate process lasting 12 to 24 months, and costs exceeding €10,000 for the heirs. Since 1 January 2026, Federal Decree-Law No. 51 of 2024 adds a further consequence: assets of deceased persons without identifiable heirs are permanently transferred to a state-managed Waqf foundation.

A DIFC will prevents this entirely. It gives your parents full control over who inherits their UAE property. The registration process is fully digital and can be completed from anywhere in the world.

This guide helps you raise the topic with your parents, handle common objections, and take the first step together.

2. What most parents don't know

The majority of foreign property owners in the UAE assume that their domestic will covers everything. This is the most widespread misconception, and it is entirely understandable. In most countries, a single will handles the complete estate.

But the UAE operates differently. Real estate on UAE soil falls under UAE jurisdiction, regardless of the owner's nationality or residence. Without a locally registered will, the local courts determine how the property is distributed.

The consequences in practice

- **Assets are frozen.** Bank accounts and property are locked immediately upon notification of death. No rent can be collected, no sale can proceed.
- **Distribution follows local rules.** Without a will, the surviving spouse may receive as little as 12.5% of the property value. The remainder is distributed among children and other family members according to fixed rules. For owners without identifiable heirs, assets may go permanently to a Waqf foundation under new UAE law.
- **The process is long and expensive.** Sworn translations, apostilles, a local lawyer, court proceedings. The total cost typically exceeds €10,000, and the timeline is 12 to 24 months.

Your parents almost certainly did not know this when they purchased the property. The agent who sold it likely did not mention it either.

3. How to start the conversation

This is the part most children find difficult. A conversation about wills touches on mortality, and that is uncomfortable for everyone involved. Many children worry about appearing self-interested or about upsetting their parents.

It helps to reframe the conversation. This is not about death. It is about protecting what your parents have built.

Three conversation openers that work

The informational approach

"Mum, Dad, I read something recently about property in Dubai and wills. Did you know that a will made here at home doesn't apply to real estate in the UAE? I was quite surprised."

This works well with parents who are curious and open to new information. You are sharing a fact, not an opinion.

The practical approach

"I was sorting through some of my own paperwork and it made me think: what's actually arranged for your apartment in Dubai? Is there anything in place, just in case?"

This works with parents who are practically minded. You are connecting it to something routine.

The protective approach

"I'm not worried that anything will happen soon, but I want to make sure everything is properly arranged. You've worked hard for that property. It would be a shame if it didn't end up where you want it to."

This works with parents who are more sensitive about the topic. You are emphasizing appreciation for what they have built.

After the first conversation

The conversation does not need to resolve everything in one sitting. Sometimes it is more effective to plant the seed and give your parents time to think. After the conversation, share something

concrete: send them the link to the information page, or suggest booking a free consultation call together.

4. The five most common objections

Objection 1: "It's already arranged in our will at home"

This is the most common misunderstanding. A will made in your parents' home country generally has no legal force over real estate in the UAE. It does not matter how well that will is drafted. UAE property requires a separate, locally registered will.

WHAT YOU CAN SAY:

"I understand you feel it's taken care of. But I looked into it, and a will made here doesn't apply to real estate in the UAE. A separate, local will is needed. They complement each other, but one doesn't replace the other."

Objection 2: "We're not going to die any time soon"

Of course not. But this argument misses the point. You arrange a will precisely because it can be done calmly now, without pressure or urgency.

WHAT YOU CAN SAY:

"This isn't about when. It's about protecting what you've built. Like insurance: you don't take it out on the day you need it. The difference is that this can be arranged in a few hours, from your living room."

Objection 3: "It's too complicated"

Many owners assume they need to fly to Dubai, hire an Arabic-speaking lawyer, or spend months on paperwork. None of that is true. A DIFC Property Will is registered entirely online. Your parents do not need to travel.

WHAT YOU CAN SAY:

"I looked into it. The entire process is digital, from home. You don't need to go anywhere. It takes a few hours, and someone guides you through every step."

Objection 4: "It's too expensive"

Guidance from UAEpropertyWills starts at €797. DIFC registration costs come on top. Compare that with the €10,000+ in legal, translation, and court costs that arise when nothing is arranged.

WHAT YOU CAN SAY:

"The guidance costs €797. That's a fraction of what it costs if nothing is arranged. And if it's easier, I'll pay for it. This is an investment in peace of mind, not an expense."

Objection 5: "We'll do it later"

"Later" is the problem. Not because something will happen tomorrow, but because postponement becomes the habit. Every month that passes without a will is a month where the risk remains.

WHAT YOU CAN SAY:

"I understand it doesn't feel urgent right now. But the good news is: it takes almost no time. A 15-minute introductory call is enough to know what's needed. Shall I schedule that for you?"

5. The gift idea

Many children find that offering to pay for the guidance removes the biggest barrier. The conversation shifts from "you need to do something" to "I've looked into it, I'll take care of it, you just need to participate."

This is not about overstepping boundaries. It is about making the process as easy as possible for your parents. Most parents appreciate the gesture once they understand what is at stake.

How it works in practice

1. **You contact UAEpropertyWills** and discuss your parents' situation. We help determine which package fits.
2. **You pay the guidance fee** (from €797). This covers preparation, personal support, document review, and guidance through the entire process.
3. **We reach out to your parents** with a personal invitation. No sales pitch, just a clear explanation of what has been arranged and why.
4. **Your parents complete the process at their own pace.** They fill in the DIFC portal with our support, or join a video session where we walk through everything together.
5. **DIFC registration costs are paid by your parents directly** (AED 7,500 for a Single Will, AED 10,000 for Mirror Wills). This separation is intentional: you give the guidance, they confirm their will by completing the registration themselves.

Good moments to give this gift

- A birthday or anniversary
- Retirement
- Or simply now, because it is needed and because you know it has not been arranged

6. After the conversation: your checklist

Once you have raised the topic, here is what you can do next.

- ☐ Ask whether your parents have a DIFC will (or any locally registered will for their UAE property)

- ☐ If yes: ask for the DIFC registration confirmation number. Check if it is still current.

- ☐ If no: schedule a free 15-minute consultation (together or on your own first)

- ☐ Gather documents: passport copies, title deed(s), names and dates of birth of intended beneficiaries

- ☐ Decide whether you want to pay for the guidance as a gift

- ☐ Share this guide or the information page with your parents

- ☐ Follow up within one week if no action has been taken

7. What a DIFC will costs

UAEpropertyWills guidance fees

Package	Fee	Suited for
Guided Registration	€797	40-minute video session. Ideal for couples or parents who prefer personal guidance
Fully Managed	€1,499	Complex situations: corporate structures, guardianship, 5+ properties

DIFC registration costs (paid separately, directly to the DIFC)

Type	Fee
Single Property Will	AED 7,500
Mirror Wills (couples)	AED 10,000
Full Will	AED 10,000 - 15,000

The DIFC portal exists and your parents can self-register. Our role is to make the process accessible: in their language, with personal support, and with the assurance that everything is filled in correctly.

Compare with the cost of doing nothing

Cost item	Estimate
Sworn translations	€2,000 - 3,000
Apostille and legalisation	€500 - 1,000
UAE lawyer	€3,700 - 7,400
Travel costs	€1,500 - 3,000
Subtotal direct costs	€7,700 - 14,400

Lost rental income (18 months)

€36,000

8. Next steps

Schedule a free consultation

15 minutes. No obligation. Together with your parents, or on your own first.

cal.com/vaetestament.nl

Or visit uaepropertywills.com/for-children for articles written specifically for adult children of UAE property owners.

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